

CHAPTER 2

UNDERSTANDING THE FAILURE OF PAKISTAN'S FIRST EXPERIMENT WITH DEMOCRACY 1947–58

Context:

Pakistan emerged during the Partition with hopes for individual and collective transformation. Anticipated cultural and material growth for India's Muslim population in the new democratic homeland.

Initial Hope and Subsequent Cynicism:

Initial optimism was replaced by cynicism within a decade.
The population became passive and looked towards military rulers for renewal.

Questions Raised:

What went wrong with Pakistan's first experiment with democracy?
Why did Pakistan's political path differ significantly from neighboring India with similar historical legacies?

Thesis of the Chapter:

The chapter argues that Pakistan's political inheritances and the Kashmir dispute had a detrimental impact on its democratic development.
Democratic consolidation was sacrificed for national security.
Centralization took precedence over the pluralist vision outlined in the 1940 Lahore Resolution.

Upcoming Analysis:

The chapter will explore the various explanations offered to understand Pakistan's political trajectory during its formative decade.

Explanations for Democratic Failure:

Politicians' Misuse of Power: Some argue that politicians were responsible for democratic failure due to their misuse of power, corruption, and factional intrigue. This argument was used to justify the 1958 coup.

Institutional Motives for Army Intervention:

It's suggested that the military had institutional motives for intervention, regardless of politicians' actions, which are often conveniently ignored.

Anti-Democratic Sentiments of Bureaucrats:

The view is that bureaucrats like Iskander Mirza and Ghulam Muhammad, who held significant positions, contributed to the coup by their distrust of politicians and their willingness to dismiss elected governments. Their early careers in the colonial bureaucracy may have nurtured these sentiments.

Ghulam Muhammad's Dismissal of the Constituent Assembly:

The dismissal of the Constituent Assembly by Ghulam Muhammad in October 1954 is seen as a pivotal moment in Pakistan's post-independence development, with critics blaming him and Chief Justice Muhammad Munir for providing legal cover for this action.

Role of Seasoned Bureaucrats:

The "misfortune" of having seasoned bureaucrats in positions of authority is identified as a significant factor contributing to democratic failure.

Decline of the Muslim League:

Unlike India's Congress party, the Muslim League did not evolve as a strong post-independence political force. It had to accommodate landlord elites to gain political influence in key provinces like Punjab, resulting in patron-client political relations that hindered democratization.

These explanations provide different perspectives on the factors contributing to Pakistan's struggle with democracy in its early years.

Ayesha Jalal's Analysis:

Ayesha Jalal's study focuses on the contradiction between state consolidation and political participation in Pakistan's early years.

Pakistan faced financial problems and strategic insecurities, which hindered the implementation of the constitutional arrangements envisioned in the 1940 Lahore Resolution.

The bureaucracy and the military emerged as the main pillars of the state, diverting resources from development to defense due to refugee crises and hostilities with India over Kashmir.

Growing strategic ties with the United States facilitated this process.

1958 Coup Background:

Political processes in the provinces were curbed but not entirely crushed during the consolidation of non-elected institutions.

The army preemptively staged a coup to prevent Bengali-led political interests from assuming power following national elections, which had a different vision for Pakistan than the West Pakistan establishment.

Role of Bureaucracy in Princely States:

In West Pakistan's Princely States, the bureaucracy oversaw the integration process. Emphasis on security over political development was evident in these states, where autocracy persisted or was replaced by centralized government control.

Failure of Post-Independence Political Unity:

The ending of temporary political unity brought by the freedom movement struggle led to the resurgence of centrifugal forces.

Centralization policies contributed to this trend, aided by US financial and military support.

Major Signposts of Pakistan Muslim League's Demise:

Key events marking the decline of the Pakistan Muslim League included the party's separation from the government in 1948, Liaquat Ali Khan's assassination in 1951, electoral defeats in East Pakistan in 1954, the support shift of West Punjab landlords to the Republican Party in 1956, and Chaudhuri Muhammad Ali's resignation as Prime Minister in 1956.

Factors Contributing to Political Decline:

Political decline is explained by factors such as the administrative culture inherited from the colonial era, weak institutionalization of the Muslim League in future Pakistan areas, and the adoption of centralizing solutions in the face of financial constraints and strategic insecurity. These points provide an overview of the historical and political context surrounding Pakistan's early years and the challenges it faced in terms of state consolidation and political participation.

British Security State in North West India:

Colonial military recruitment policies in the late 19th century focused on the Punjab, considering it the main army center.

The "martial races" ideology and Punjab's strategic location ensured a steady supply of recruits while keeping them away from Indian nationalism.

The Punjab's loyalty during the 1857 revolt solidified strategic alliances between the British and military contractors, creating a tradition of authoritarianism.

The administrative ethos prioritized maintaining political order over fostering representative institutions.

The term "viceregalism" describes the authoritarian governance legacy of colonial rule, characterized by paternalism, bureaucratic discretion, and personalized authority.

This ethos was institutionalized in the Frontier Crimes Regulation.

Even after the NWFP's separation from the Punjab, the strategic importance of the region persisted, emphasizing the need for order.

Political participation was delayed in Balochistan and Frontier regions, and political rights were restricted.

Electoral politics in Balochistan were limited to the Quetta Municipality until late.

The bureaucratic attitudes from the British security state were inherited by leading Pakistani bureaucrats of the 1950s.

Legacy of Freedom Struggle:

Landownership and political power traditionally went hand in hand in North West India.

Rapid changes in landownership occurred before colonial rule, but British demilitarization created a more static, village-based society.

The colonial state reinforced the influence of local power-holders, especially after the conservative reaction following the 1857 revolt.

Despite colonial stereotypes, many of the elites collaborating with the British were not ancient hierarchies but of modern origin.

Variation in Governance Culture:

Bengal stood out as an exception to the security state tradition, with a more conducive environment for the growth of democracy and civil society compared to other Muslim-majority areas.

Pakistan faced the challenge of accommodating varying colonial inheritances.

Challenges in Shifting Governance Culture:

The character of the freedom struggle and the chaos surrounding the 1947 Partition prevented a complete shift away from the viceregalism tradition in West Pakistan areas.

These points illustrate how historical legacies from British colonial rule and the freedom struggle shaped Pakistan's political landscape and governance culture.

Role of Landholders in Colonial State:

Colonial authorities regarded landholders as important intermediaries in governing.

Several measures were taken to bolster the position of landholders, including controlling land transfers through primogeniture, limiting land acquisition by non-agriculturalists, granting land for state services, granting police and judicial powers, and drawing political constituencies to align with landholders' control.

Landholders served as gatekeepers for local populations' access to British officials.

Leading families received honorary awards and titles, enhancing their status and prestige.

Enhancement of Landed and Tribal Elite:

This practice was common across the future West Pakistan region.

In the North West Frontier Province, larger Khans benefited from British patronage.

In the Punjab, large landlords, biraderis (kinship networks, tribes) heads, and Sufi religious leaders with landholdings attached to shrines gained influence.

In Sindh, pirs and waderos were rewarded as intermediaries.

Tribal sardars in Balochistan also played a similar role.

Muslim League's Strategy:

The Muslim League recognized the power of local ruling elites and aimed to use their influence in political mobilization rather than bypassing them.

The party formed strategic alliances with these elites to secure their support.

These alliances were crucial in delivering votes during the 1945–6 elections, which were portrayed as a referendum on the Pakistan demand.

However, this strategy had its drawbacks, as landholders were often reluctant to organize local League branches themselves, leading to a lack of local roots for the Muslim League.

Organizational Challenges:

Muslim League membership was limited in Punjab and even lower in Sindh.

Factional rivalries and infighting were common within the Provincial Muslim Leagues in the future Pakistan areas.

These challenges undermined party loyalty, discipline, and the establishment of a pyramid of branches like the Congress had.

Regional Variations in Leadership and Influence:

The Muslim League leadership primarily came from the UP region.

Few leaders in the future Pakistan areas had government experience.

The Congress emerged as a major party with a majority of Muslim seats in the 1946 elections.

In Balochistan, the Muslim League had limited influence, and politics often centered around demands for greater Balochistan.

Balochistan's Political Landscape:

The Kalat State National Party (KSNP) played a significant role in Balochistan politics.

The Khan of Kalat initially supported the KSNP's greater Balochistan movement but eventually banned it when demands for democratic reform grew.

The tradition of limited Muslim League influence persisted in Balochistan until 1947.

These points highlight the complex political landscape in Pakistan during the colonial era, characterized by alliances with local elites, regional variations in leadership, and the challenges faced by political parties like the Muslim League in building organizational strength.

Character of the Freedom Struggle:

Pakistan's emergence was seen by some as a legacy of British divide-and-rule policies rather than a result of principled mass struggle.

Author Ashok Kapur argues that Pakistan's separate status was achieved without a strong sense of idealism, public service, or self-sacrifice.

However, this view does not consider the democratic institution and efforts in Bengal led by Abul Hashim, which aimed at "fighting for liberation from all forms of oppression."

The post-independence dismantling of this platform and its recapture by conservative elements contributed to the Muslim League's decline in Bengal.

Conflicting Understandings of Pakistan Demand:

Different groups had varying understandings of the Pakistan demand, such as landowners seeking to protect their interests, bureaucrats and army officers eyeing rapid promotion, businessmen looking to reduce Hindu domination of trade and industry, and religious classes aiming to implement their vision of Islam.

In Bengal, supporters believed they were fighting for a sovereign East Pakistan state with transformed agrarian relations.

This diversity in interpretations led to unity primarily against the Congress and Hindu "others," fostering a negative form of Pakistani nationalism.

Political Culture of Intolerance:

The freedom struggle contributed to a culture of intolerance in Pakistan.

Opposition to the Muslim League was increasingly seen as unpatriotic, and the formation of new political parties in opposition was discouraged.

This intolerance had its roots in the freedom struggle's negative characteristics.

Centralization and Ethno-Linguistic Tensions:

Attempts to establish a centralized state around the Muslim League and Urdu-Islam unity created tensions with regional ethno-linguistic groups.

Centralization was justified by the need for unity in the face of threats from India and Afghanistan.

Centralization had its roots in the character of the freedom movement itself, which was highly centralized and dominated by members from the Muslim minority areas rather than the future Pakistan areas.

Legacy of Partition:

Pakistan's creation was marked by mass migrations, communal massacres, and the displacement of millions of people.

The death toll from Partition was estimated between 200,000 and 1 million, with millions of refugees in the Punjab region alone.

Scarce government resources were diverted to address refugee problems and military concerns.

Pakistan's financial resources were heavily allocated to defense, with up to 70% of the national income dedicated to it.

Partition's aftermath created tensions between provinces and the center over refugee resettlement, leading to executive action against elected representatives.

Impact on Sub-National Movements:

The trauma of Partition has influenced India and Pakistan's responses to sub-national movements.

Both countries have been unwilling to entertain another Partition and have used force to suppress ethno-nationalist movements.

Pakistan faced difficulties in countering regional nationalist movements in East Bengal, Balochistan, and Sindh.

Kashmir Dispute:

The dispute over Jammu and Kashmir symbolized India and Pakistan's competing conceptions of national identity.

Hari Singh's decision to accede to India led to hostilities between India and Pakistan, United Nations intervention, and the de facto division of Jammu and Kashmir.

The dispute continues to impact the rivalry between India and Pakistan and their perceptions of national identity.

These points highlight the complex historical factors that contributed to authoritarianism in Pakistan, including the character of the freedom struggle, the legacy of Partition, and the challenges of nation-building in a diverse and divided region.

Role of Punjab:

Punjab gradually emerged as the core of the new state of Pakistan after Partition.

Punjabi political leadership, initially provincialist, shifted toward the center's interests.

The dissolution of the first Constituent Assembly and the creation of the One Unit scheme in West Pakistan marked the consolidation of Punjabi influence.

The emergence of Punjabi landowners and biraderi leaders willing to align with the military and bureaucracy for Punjabi hegemony.

The shifting of the federal capital from Karachi to Islamabad symbolized Punjab's growing influence.

Punjabi Refugees and Assimilation:

The majority of Pakistan's Partition refugees were Punjabis, who did not adopt the mohajir label. Punjabi refugees faced intense violence during Partition.

The exclusion of Punjabi-majority districts from Pakistan deepened their sense of injustice.

While Punjabi refugees were relatively easily assimilated into Punjabi society, they became a constituency for martial law governments and right-wing parties.

Language Policy and Identity:

The colonial state's decision to make Urdu, rather than Punjabi, the official language of the government contributed to the gradual melding of Pakistan and Punjabi identities.

Contemporary attitudes in Pakistan often marginalize Punjabi as a language.

The neutralization of a potential Punjabi ethnic question was initiated before the refugee influx.

Ethnic Mobilization and Resistance:

Resistance to the political structure centered around Punjab occurred in various provinces.

Ethnic mobilizations and resistance initially emerged in the North West Frontier Province, Balochistan, and Sindh.

Bengali responses to the center's attempts to deny them majority democratic power were particularly disruptive for Pakistan's political development.

These points highlight the growing influence of Punjab in Pakistan's political landscape and the challenges posed by ethnic mobilizations and resistance in various provinces, which contributed to the country's complex political dynamics.

North West Frontier Province (NWFP):

Concerns about Pakhtun nationalism and the threat of Afghan irredentism.

Pakistan's efforts to counter Afghan claims on certain territories.

The role of Khan Abdul Qaiyum in the NWFP and his cooperation with the central government.

Measures taken by Qaiyum, including agrarian reforms and repression of political opponents.

The influence of the One Unit scheme in creating tensions between the center and the province.

Balochistan:

The historical tradition of tribal insurgency and military intervention in the region.

Balochistan's accession to Pakistan in 1948 under disputed circumstances.

The centralization policies of the Pakistan state, including the merging of Kalat with other territories.

The rise of Baloch nationalism and armed resistance against Pakistan.

The role of martial law in Balochistan and its use as a pretext by Ayub Khan.

Sindh:

Dissatisfaction in Sindh due to an influx of Punjabi settlers and administrative decisions.

Efforts by leaders like M.A. Khuhro to safeguard Sindhi interests.

Clashes between Khuhro and the central government over various issues.

The emergence of Sindhi ethnic identity and opposition to the One Unit scheme.

The appointment of Khuhro to support the One Unit scheme despite his earlier disqualification.

East Bengal:

The role of language and cultural identity in East Bengal's political dynamics.

Protests and demonstrations related to language issues, leading to the February 21 movement.

Growing feelings of economic disparity and exploitation by West Pakistan.

Accusations of "internal colonialism" and resource transfer from East to West Pakistan.

The impact of these issues on demands for political autonomy and separatism.

These points highlight the diverse regional dynamics and challenges Pakistan faced during its early years, including language movements, economic disparities, and growing demands for autonomy and identity.

Constitution-Making and Disputes:

Constitution-making in Pakistan faced challenges related to provincial-center relations. Disputes between the two wings (East and West Pakistan) over issues like joint versus separate electorates hindered the process of democratic consolidation.

The One Unit Scheme was an attempt to undermine the democratic majority of East Bengal.

In 1950, Bengali counter-proposals raised issues that eventually led to the separation of East Bengal from West Pakistan.

The Grand National Convention in Dhaka in 1950, organized by the Awami League, proposed a United States of Pakistan with regional autonomy.

1954 Provincial Elections:

The 1954 provincial elections in East Pakistan were a major setback for the Muslim League, closely associated with the central government.

The Muslim League won only 10 seats out of 309 in the East Bengal Assembly, while the United Front secured 223 seats.

The electoral outcome reflected support for many pre-independence policies, but the center's refusal to acknowledge it drove Bengalis toward separation.

Political Instability and Changing Alliances:

Fazlul Huq's government in East Pakistan was dismissed after a brief period, partly due to allegations of pro-Communist and pro-Indian leanings.

The formation of the United Front in East Pakistan, with the support of various opposition parties, marked a shift in political dynamics.

Changes in government and shifting alliances, including Huq's role as Governor, affected the political landscape.

National Awami Party and Ideological Clashes:

The emergence of the National Awami Party further complicated political dynamics and reduced Suhrawardy's usefulness to the central government.

The ideological clash between different groups within the Awami League intensified demands for provincial autonomy.

The National Awami Party called for the abolition of the One Unit scheme, a neutral foreign policy, and regional autonomy.

Demise of Democracy and Military Intervention:

Chaotic and opportunistic political maneuvering discredited democracy.

Physical confrontations and a lack of political stability paved the way for military intervention.

The military coup led by Ayub Khan and Mirza in October 1958 marked the end of this period of political instability.

Conclusion:

Pakistan displayed aspects of "procedural" democracy, including elections, but lacked characteristics of "social" democracy that would address social inequalities and promote participation.

Legacy issues from the colonial era, the freedom movement, and the partition process hindered democratic consolidation.

Pakistan's precarious strategic position shifted power from politicians to the military and bureaucracy, leading to centralization and authoritarianism.

The initial years of independence set a path of dependency that contributed to future military interventions and democratic challenges in Pakistan.